

The Stonington Sale — Where Things Stand, in Plain English

Informational only — not legal advice. We review everything with Zach (our agent) and, where needed, an Ohio attorney before signing.

Prepared 2026-08-08. Every number in here comes straight from the deal-room research files — nothing is guessed. If a real contractor quote arrives, it beats everything in this report.

1. Where we are, in one paragraph

We sold the house for **\$585,000** to committed buyers — the Sipniewskis, a couple who offered over asking before anyone else even saw the place. They had their inspection, and instead of nitpicking, they asked us to fix one specific list: the roof and its related bits, plus a radon system (radon is a naturally occurring soil gas; the test came back high, which is common in Cincinnati basements and very fixable). Here's the important part: **we must answer them by Monday, August 10**. If we say nothing, the contract automatically treats us as having agreed to do everything exactly as they wrote it — the one outcome we'd be choosing by accident instead of on purpose. Closing is **August 28**. This report walks through what they asked for, what it costs, and the three good ways we can answer.

2. The three dates that matter

Date	What it means, plainly
Sun/Mon, Aug 10 (end of day)	Our answer is due. Silence = we've automatically agreed to do every repair exactly as the buyers wrote it.
Wed, Aug 12 (end of day)	Only matters if we counter-offer: both sides must sign the counter by this day, or the contract automatically ends. That's why anything we send Monday needs to be pre-agreed by phone first.
Fri, Aug 28	Closing day — we get paid, they get keys. (Their re-check of any repairs happens around Aug 25.)

3. What they asked for, item by item

Eight items, all on one theme: **water staying out of the house**, plus the radon system. Here's each one in plain words. The **bold number** is the most-likely cost; the range behind it runs from "if we're lucky" to "worst realistic case."

Wind-bent shingles on the front lower roof (RS-1)

What it is: Some shingles on the lower front section of the roof got creased by wind — bent back hard enough to leave a fold line, like a paperback cover. Creased shingles can lift and let water under them.

Why the inspector flagged it: Creased shingles fail earlier than intact ones, and the crease is visible proof of wind damage.

What it costs: **\$800–\$1,500** most likely (\$400 low, \$1,800 high). A roofer swaps the damaged shingles — routine work.

Worst case: **\$6,000.** That only happens if two things go wrong at once: our 2014 shingle color turns out to be discontinued, *and* the buyers refuse a close-match patch — forcing a re-shingle of that whole front section so the color change lands on a natural line.

How we'd handle it: Ask every roofer up front, "is our shingle color still made?" and get the buyers' agent to accept "closest available match" in writing. That one email caps this item at ~\$1,800. There's also a quiet silver lining here — see the insurance note in Section 5.

Buckled roof sheathing (RS-2)

What it is: Sheathing is the plywood layer under the shingles — the roof's "floor." The inspector saw it buckling (rippling) in at least three spots, which usually means moisture got to it at some point.

Why the inspector flagged it: A wavy deck can mean soft or rotted wood, and shingles don't seal well over ripples.

What it costs: **\$1,500–\$3,000** most likely (\$1,000 low, \$5,500 high). A roofer opens those spots, replaces the affected sheets, and re-shingles over them.

Worst case: **\$11,000** — if opening the roof reveals rot that spread well beyond those spots, or the roofer refuses spot repairs and insists on redoing that whole roof section. This is the biggest single "surprise" risk on the list.

How we'd handle it: Get each roofer's per-sheet price for extra sheathing *in writing before work starts*, so a surprise becomes a known unit price instead of an open checkbook. And there's a hard ceiling on all the roof items combined: a complete new roof on our house runs about \$11,000–\$18,000 in Cincinnati, so no pile of repairs should ever cost more than that.

Kick-out flashing (RS-3)

What it is: Kick-out flashing is a small piece of bent metal at the spot where the roof edge meets a wall — it kicks rainwater into the gutter instead of letting it run down the wall. Ours is missing at some of those spots, and there's staining on the wall to prove the water's been going where it shouldn't.

Why the inspector flagged it: Years of water running down a wall eventually gets behind the siding or brick.

What it costs: **\$1,200–\$1,800** most likely (\$700 low, \$2,200 high). Small parts, skilled labor.

Worst case: **\$2,800** — if every one of those spots is on brick. On brick, the flashing has to be ground into the mortar joints (a masonry job), which is slower and pricier than tucking it under wood siding.

How we'd handle it: Bundle it with the roofer's visit — same crew, same ladders, one bill.

Loose wood siding near the roofline, rear upper wall (EG-2)

What it is: A section of wood siding up near the roof edge at the back of the house has come loose.

Why the inspector flagged it: Loose siding lets water behind it; it's also a two-story-height item, so it needs proper ladders or staging.

What it costs: **\$300–\$600** most likely (\$200 low, \$900 high). The cheapest item on the list.

Worst case: **\$1,200** — if there's rot behind the loose boards.

How we'd handle it: Same roofer, same trip. They're already up there.

Chimney crown and flashing (RS-6)

What it is: The crown is the concrete "lid" that sheds rain off the top of the chimney; flashing is the metal skirt sealing where the chimney passes through the roof. The inspector says ours is damaged enough that water can currently get into the chimney structure. (The notice says "crowns/caps" — plural — so there may be two.)

Why the inspector flagged it: Water inside masonry plus Cincinnati freeze-thaw winters is how chimneys slowly crumble.

What it costs: **\$2,000–\$3,500** most likely (\$700 low, \$4,500 high). The realistic fix is a full crown replacement — a chimney company forms and pours a new concrete lid — not a paint-on sealant, which likely wouldn't satisfy the "water can penetrate" finding.

Worst case: **\$8,000** — if the crew gets up there and finds the top few rows of brick are water-damaged and need rebuilding before a new crown can be poured, or if there really are two crowns.

How we'd handle it: This is chimney-company work, not roofer work — their invoice is the clean paper trail. Lock the scope in writing first ("new poured crown + flashing = item satisfied"), and call early: chimney companies get slammed starting late August.

Gutters — clean, re-secure, and re-slope (RS-4 and RS-5)

What it is: Gutters full of debris, some hangers (the brackets holding the gutters to the house) loose or failed, and some runs pitched wrong — tilted so water pools instead of flowing to the downspouts.

Why the inspector flagged it: Gutters that overflow or pool dump water next to the foundation and across the wood trim — this is related to the staining from the flashing item.

What it costs: **\$600–\$1,100** most likely for both together (\$350 low, \$1,800 high). Our house has a lot of gutter — roughly 150–220 feet — at two-story height, which is why this isn't a \$200 job.

Worst case: **\$3,500** — if re-hanging the gutters reveals rotted fascia (the wood board the gutters bolt onto) that needs replacing behind the failed brackets.

How we'd handle it: Fold it into the roofer's invoice and ask them to check the fascia during the estimate — better to know before work starts than discover it mid-job.

Radon mitigation system (RADON)

What it is: Radon is an invisible, odorless gas that seeps up from the soil; long exposure at high levels raises lung cancer risk, which is why there's a standard action threshold of 4.0. Our basement tested at **13.6** — high, but very common around here and completely fixable. The fix is a mitigation system: a sealed pipe and a small fan that pulls the gas from under the basement slab and vents it above the roof.

One-day install.

Why the inspector flagged it: The contract said mitigate if the test comes back at 4.0 or higher. It did.

What it costs: **\$1,300–\$1,800** most likely (\$1,000 low, \$2,500 high), installed by an Ohio-licensed radon contractor, with a re-test afterward proving the level dropped below 4.0.

Worst case: \$3,500 — if the basement's quirks (the cracks and old water signs the buyers already know about) force a second suction point or extra sealing to make the system pull properly.

How we'd handle it: Get 2–3 quotes from state-licensed installers, ask each up front what a second suction point would add, and book fast — the install plus the re-test needs about a week of runway, which fits comfortably if it's booked by ~Aug 12.

The whole list, added up

	If we're lucky	Most likely	Bad day	Rational ceiling
Everything the buyers asked for	~\$4,350	~\$7,900–\$12,900	~\$18,300	~\$26,000 — and it can't go past that, because at that point you just put on a whole new roof (~\$11–18K) instead

4. What they did NOT ask for

This part matters as much as the list itself. The inspection also turned up scarier-sounding items — cracks in the foundation, an older electrical panel, an aging furnace, some basement water signs — and the buyers **waived all of them**. They looked at the whole report and asked only for the water-related roof work and the radon system. That's not the behavior of people hunting for an exit or grinding us for money. That's the behavior of people who want this house and are protecting the thing they're about to own. It's the single most reassuring fact in this whole file.

5. The money picture

The ask is affordable. The whole list most likely costs **\$7,900–\$12,900**. Against a \$585,000 sale, that's about 1.5–2% of the price.

The alternative is much worse. If we refused and the deal died, the math says walking away would cost us roughly **\$12,000–\$30,000 more than just closing** — a lower likely resale price, the frozen deposit mess, and re-listing friction — *plus* months of mortgage, taxes, and utilities carrying an empty house into a slower fall market. And Ohio law would require us to disclose everything we now know — the radon number, the roof items, even the waived items — to every future buyer. There is no version of "no" that comes out ahead. Every version of "yes, structured well" does.

How the three response choices compare financially: the deal-room's net-proceeds model ran all three (repairs, part-credit, full-credit) and they land within a few thousand dollars of each other at the

midpoints. So the choice isn't really about the headline number — it's about **risk and timing**: a credit means zero out-of-pocket before closing and nothing to re-inspect, while doing the work ourselves means fronting contractor bills before the sale money exists, but keeps other advantages (next section, and the cushions below).

Two cushions working in our favor:

1. **Our Erie insurance policy.** The creased shingles are wind damage, and our policy is unusually good for exactly this: a flat **\$1,000 deductible**, replacement-cost coverage, and a roof young enough (2014) to be fully covered. If **we** do the roof work, a documented wind claim may reimburse much of it after closing. The catch: the damage must be **photographed and documented before anything is repaired** — and the claim only exists if we're the ones doing the work (a credit to the buyers forfeits it).
2. **The escrow refund.** After the mortgage is paid off at closing, the roughly **\$4,000** sitting in our mortgage escrow account comes back to us a few weeks later. It's not closing-table money, but it's real money on the other side.

6. Why home sales fall through — and how we're protected

It's worth knowing the actual odds, because they're on our side.

Nationally, **about 1 in 7 signed home sales has been falling apart before closing** in the current market — Redfin counted 13.4% of pending sales canceled in March 2026, the highest levels for this era (redfin.com/news/contract-cancellations-march-2026). Sounds scary until you look at *why* they die.

Redfin's survey of 443 of its agents found that 70% of dead deals died over exactly one thing: inspection and repair disagreements (redfin.com/news/home-purchase-cancellations-august-2025). That is precisely the phase we are in right now — and it's the phase that **ends the moment we respond well on Monday**. The #1 killer of home sales is a stage we exit this week, with buyers who made a narrow, reasonable ask.

What's left after that is mostly on the buyers' side of the table, and they've pre-paid to reassure us:

- **Buyer financing falls through** in about 28% of dead deals (same Redfin survey). That's their lender and their paperwork, not ours. But these buyers put down **\$10,000 in earnest money** — a deposit they'd forfeit by walking away without cause.
- **The appraisal comes in low** in only about 8% of sales (Fannie Mae's analysis of 6.5 million purchase appraisals — fanniemae.com/media/48121/display). And these buyers signed an addendum agreeing to **cover up to \$10,000 of any appraisal gap** out of their own pocket.

Buyers who offer over asking, put down \$10K, pre-commit another \$10K against a low appraisal, and waive the scary inspection items are the statistical profile of buyers who close. Our job is simply not to give them a reason to reconsider: answer on time, put everything in writing, and never reopen a settled point.

7. Our three choices Monday (and the recommendation)

The response form gives us three realistic paths. All three are good; they differ in who does the work and who holds the risk.

Branch A — we do the radon, they get a credit for the roof. We install the radon system before closing (licensed contractor, passing re-test — an objective number, no arguments possible), and instead of roof repairs we give the buyers roughly **\$8,500** toward their closing costs so they fix the roof their way, on their schedule, with their contractor.

Why it's safe: the messy, surprise-prone roof work becomes a fixed dollar amount and stops being our problem, while the one item with a clean pass/fail test gets done by us.

Branch B — we do all the work ourselves. We accept their list (with one clarifying sentence pinning down the sheathing scope so "repair the affected spots" can't quietly become "redo the roof"), then hire the roofer, chimney company, and radon installer to finish by ~Aug 24.

Why it's safe: saying yes to what they asked for carries **zero risk of the contract blowing up on a technicality** — no counter-offer, no Aug 12 fuse. And with the new estimates, this branch got *more* attractive: if quotes come in soft, the whole list might cost ~\$4,400 — half of any credit — and the Erie insurance reimbursement only exists on this path.

Branch C — pure credit for everything. Roughly **\$10,500** toward their closing costs, covering the whole list including radon. Nothing to schedule, nothing to re-inspect, zero out-of-pocket before closing.

Why it's safe: it's the cleanest possible closing — there is literally nothing left to argue about at the walk-through. It's the fallback if the radon install can't be booked in time.

The recommendation (from the full strategy review): don't pick blind — **Zach calls Amy (the buyers' agent) first**, ideally Saturday, and simply asks whether his clients would rather have money or have the repairs done. Their answer picks the branch:

What Amy says	We send Monday
"Money works for them"	Branch A (radon done by us + ~\$8,500 credit) — or C if that fits better
"They want the repairs done"	Branch B — safe default, no contract fuse
Call doesn't happen / unclear	Branch B — the safe default
Radon can't be booked in time	Branch C (~\$10,500 all-in credit)

And the one iron rule above all of it: **never let Monday pass without answering.** Even the "worst" deliberate answer beats the automatic one. Meanwhile, the single most valuable thing anyone can do this weekend is get a **real roofer quote and a real chimney quote** — one real number replaces every estimate in this report and tells us instantly whether doing the work beats writing the credit.

8. What we need to decide by Sunday night

Short list. Everything can be done by phone and e-signature — no meetings needed.

- **Pick the branch together** (after Zach reports back on the Amy call).

■ **Agree the dollar figure** if it's a credit branch (~\$8,500 Branch A / ~\$10,500 Branch C are the researched suggestions — the final number is ours to set with Zach).

■ **Both of us sign the response packet Sunday** — Zach will have it ready; e-signature is fine and legally valid.

■ **Zach delivers it Monday afternoon** and gets written confirmation of receipt.

That's it. Answer well on Monday, and the hardest part of this sale is behind us — with committed buyers, protected deposits, and 18 days to closing.

Numbers and claims in this report trace to: REPAIR_ESTIMATE.md (all repair costs, v2 house-specific) · net-proceeds-scenarios.md (money picture, Erie and escrow cushions) · why-sales-fall-through.md (fall-through rates and causes) · COUNCIL_VERDICT.md and RESPONSE_MEMO.md (the recommendation ladder) · DEAL_BRIEF.md (dates, parties, contract mechanics).